

FEATURED

Area police share license plate reader data for immigration, unstated reasons, records show

 Cornelius Frolik - Staff Writer May 20, 2026						
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Law enforcement agencies across the state and country routinely access local police departments’ automated license plate reader data for immigration and often unstated purposes, a Dayton Daily News investigation found.

The Dayton Daily News requested ALPR audit records from many local agencies and received data from police departments in Kettering, Miami Twp. and Tipp City. Miamisburg and Springboro police also provided limited information.

The records show that law enforcement agencies across Ohio and the United States conduct thousands of searches of local police data every single day. In January alone, hundreds of local searches listed “immigration” as a search reason.

Far more often, agencies don’t make it clear why they want local ALPR data, which is collected by cameras posted on busy roadways that capture images of license plates and other visual information of passing cars.

DAYTON DAILY NEWS INVESTIGATES

Automated license plate readers



The city of Dayton recently suspended its use of fixed-point automatic license plate readers after disclosing camera data was being accessed by outside agencies for immigration-related searches.

We obtained data from other area police departments to reveal how ALPR data is shared, and for what reasons.

» Area police license plate reader data routinely accessed for immigration investigations, records show

» Privacy advocates: Legislation, guardrails needed for police license plate readers

» How Kettering, other area police departments share license plate reader data

Law enforcement officers are supposed to state a reason for every search of jurisdictions' ALPR databases, but network audit records reveal that the reasons provided can be vague or indecipherable. Some search reasons just include the words "investigation," "investigation pending," "other," "other law enforcement purpose" or a series of numbers, sometimes apparently tied to police codes or incident reports.

"It can be whatever you want — you just type it in — there's literally no safeguard," said Melissa Bertolo, a Dayton resident who is a founding member of the Coalition for Public Protection, a local community advocacy group that pushes for transparency and accountability for police tools and practices.

Use of surveillance tools for immigration enforcement is divisive. Many people were outraged to recently learn that the Dayton Police Department allowed other police agencies to scan its database thousands of times for immigration purposes, violating policy and breaking promises that police leaders made to the community.



Dayton City Manager Shelley Dickstein speaks Friday, May 1, 2026, during a media briefing at the Safety Building about the indefinite suspension of using automated license plate readers amid an independent review. JEN BALDUF/STAFF
Daniel Susco - Staff Writer

The Dayton Police Department, the Montgomery County Sheriff's Office and other regional police departments denied Dayton Daily News requests, made under Ohio public records law, that seek to obtain audit information showing how those agencies are sharing Flock ALPR data. Officials say the records are confidential and exempt from public records law. This news outlet is currently disputing those assertions.

ALPRs are used by law enforcement agencies across southwest Ohio, including Springfield, Clark County, Hamilton, Middletown, West Chester Twp. and Butler County. This news outlet is seeking audit data from these agencies.

Kettering changes practice

On May 4, Kettering police changed their practice “so that an agency can no longer access Kettering’s cameras just by stating it’s for immigration purposes,” according to police Chief Chip Protsman.

May 4 is the same day the Dayton Daily News emailed questions to the agency noting how often Kettering’s data was being accessed for immigration investigations and asking if the agency was OK with outside agencies using ALPR data for immigration purposes.

Kettering Mayor Bryan Suddith declined to answer questions from the Dayton Daily News, providing only a statement saying: “I am confident that our policy aligns with our residents’ desire for a safe and secure Kettering while simultaneously protecting their privacy.”

Other local officials say their ALPR technology is being used appropriately, in accordance with department policy and Ohio law, and that they have taken steps to ensure proper oversight and protect people’s privacy.

“The police department maintains policies governing system access and use, conducts regular audits and reviews system activity to help ensure compliance with applicable laws and departmental standards,” said Tipp City Manager Eric Mack.

“We understand the public concerns surrounding privacy, data access and accountability, and we remain committed to using this technology responsibly, transparently and in a manner consistent with both public safety needs and community expectations.”

Tipp City’s policy on ALPR data says it’s accessible “for legitimate law enforcement purposes only.”

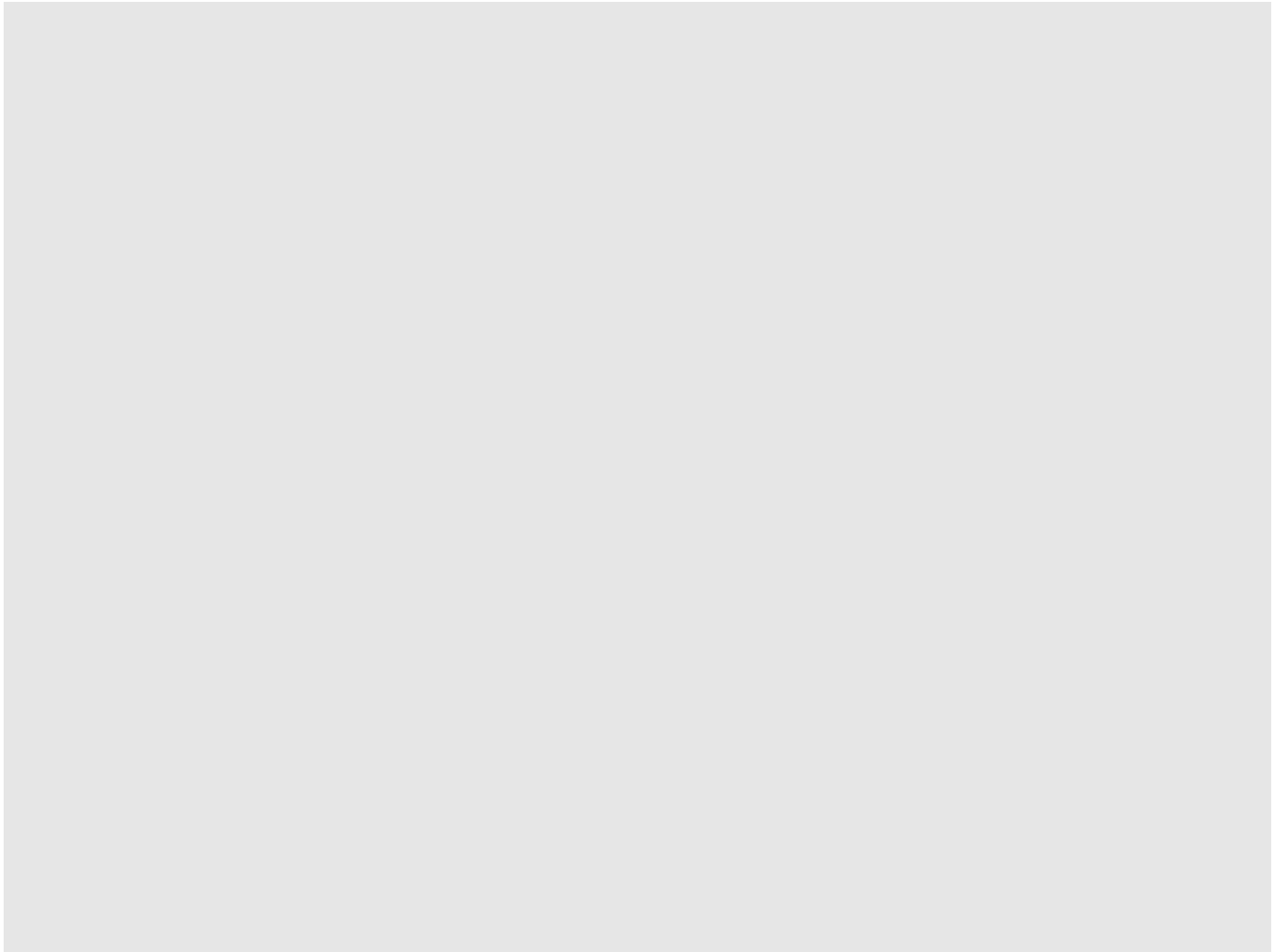
Immigration searches by local agencies

Kettering’s data has been accessed for immigration-related reasons by a variety of local and out-of-state agencies.

Of the 184 times immigration was listed as a reason for accessing Kettering’s ALPR data in January, 23 searches were done by the Sharonville Police Department, 19 came from the Greene County Sheriff’s Office, 10 from the Ohio Bureau of Motor Vehicles, three from the Montgomery County Sheriff’s Office and two from the Miamisburg Police Department,

according to network audit records. Dozens of other immigration searches were conducted by the Grant County, Ind., Sheriff's Office, who included the word "test" as part of the stated search purpose.

Immigration was the listed reason for another 53 searches in audit data from March 8 to April 7.



A Flock automated license plate reader at West Stroop Road and Cordell Drive in Kettering. The city has 10 fixed-site cameras, but police officials say they stopped sharing data with agencies who list immigration as a reason May 4. Nick Graham / Staff

Nick Graham / Staff

The Greene and Montgomery county sheriffs' offices listed the reason for some of their searches of Kettering's database as "Immigration (civil/administrative)." Neither agency has an agreement with ICE that allows them to enforce immigration laws.

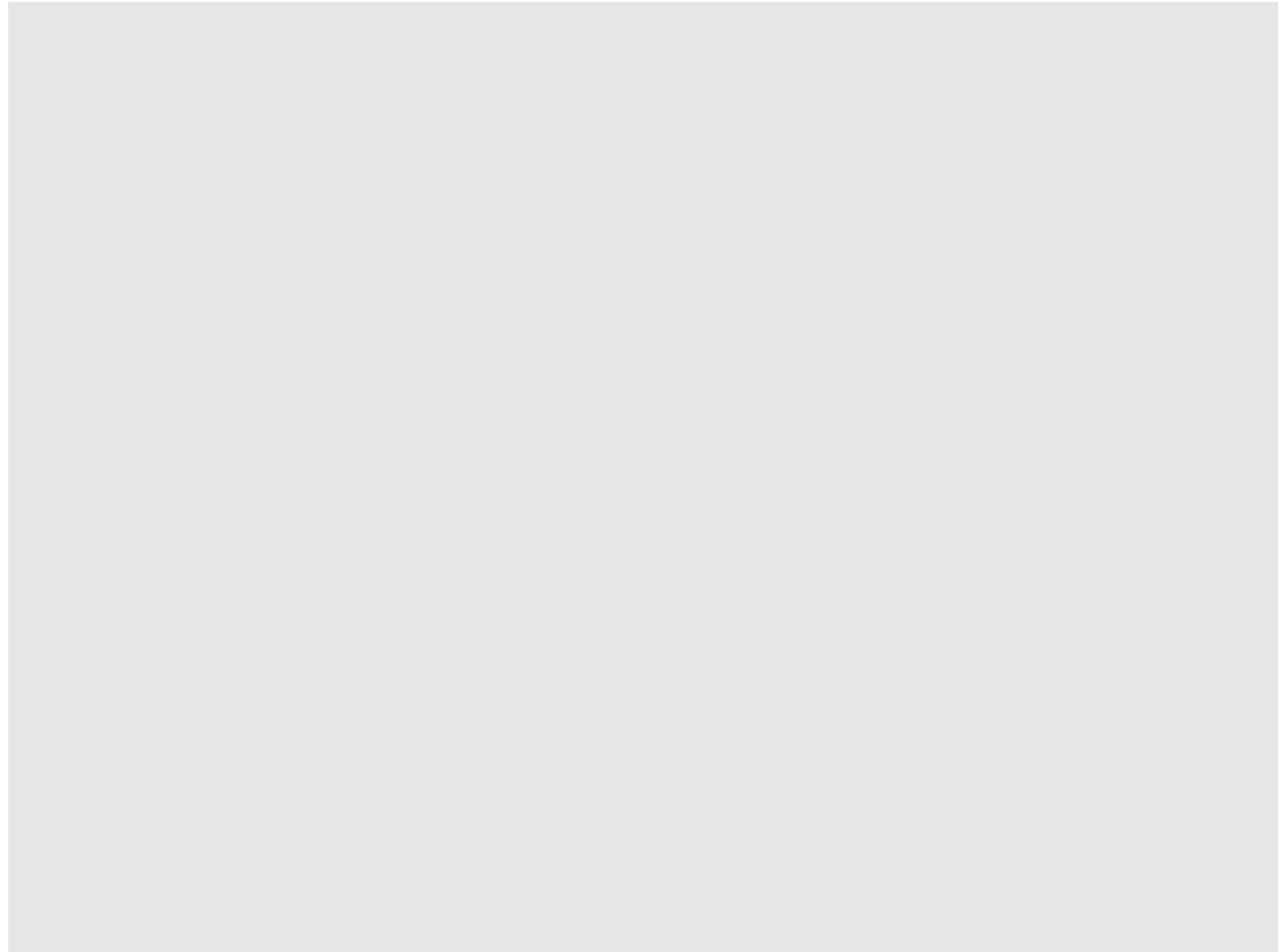
In an interview last month, Greene County Sheriff Scott Anger said his office does not have a formal agreement with ICE but staff work cooperatively with federal agents.

“Sometimes I think that by not cooperating with the federal people you’re making it more unsafe ... because you have people operating independently within your counties,” said Anger, who did not respond to requests for comment for this story. “We know our county and we know how to help them take care of what they need to do. That’s always our goal is to make sure everybody stays safe and that we work together.”

Sharonville police say Flock is a useful tool in solving crimes. They say Sharonville doesn’t enforce immigration laws and the searches listed in Kettering’s data were traced back to an officer who “mistakenly selected ‘immigration’ from the “case type” drop down in a hurried effort from an in-car computer to get information on a vehicle that he was hoping to locate.”

Miamisburg police Chief Mike Brem said he could not definitively identify the two queries about immigration that showed up in Kettering police’s network audit based on details provided by the Dayton Daily News. But he said they might have been related to an investigation involving two people who were in the country unlawfully who were arrested in connection to allegations of sexual assault against juvenile family members.

“Following those arrests, detectives were coordinating formal criminal charges and investigative efforts prior to the possibility of deportation proceedings occurring,” he said.



An automated license plate reader at Springboro Pike, north of Ohio 725 in Miami Twp. Records show that law enforcement agencies across Ohio and the United States conduct thousands of searches of local police data every day.

Nick Graham / Staff

Nick Graham / Staff

Out of state searches

Between early March and early April, dozens of law enforcement agencies performed about 475 searches of the Tipp City Police Department's ALPR database explicitly for immigration-related reasons, according to network audit records obtained by the Dayton Daily News.

Tipp City police allow thousands of police departments, sheriffs' offices and other agencies around the state and nation to access its ALPR data. About 95% of the immigration-related searches were conducted by out-of-state law enforcement, including police in Texas, Florida, Alabama, Indiana and Louisiana.

Flock, the company that makes ALPR devices and provides support to users, says U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement and the Department of Homeland Security do not have direct access to its customers' data, systems and cameras. However, the company acknowledges that there is nothing stopping its customers from working with ICE and DHS and sharing data with federal authorities.

The Dayton Daily News determined that at least 40% of the agencies that performed immigration-associated searches of the Tipp City Police Department's database have cooperation agreements with ICE that authorize their staff to participate in immigration-enforcement activities.

This includes the Jefferson County, Ala., Sheriff's Office, which accessed Tipp City's data 47 times in a month, listing the reason as "Immigration (civil/administrative)." The Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission queried the city's data 25 times, with the reason usually listed as "Immigration (criminal) — I.C.E."

Mack, city manager for Tipp City, said the city takes privacy, transparency, accountability and the lawful use of technology very seriously. He said ALPR data is collected and used in compliance with departmental policy, Ohio law and Flock system contractual requirements.

Flock cameras have helped police make more than 100 arrests for serious criminal offenses, Mack said. He said the police department performs ALPR audits quarterly to ensure compliance with department standards and the law. He said immigration searches of Tipp City's system were done by external agencies through broader law enforcement information-sharing networks and were not initiated, directed or accessed by Tipp City police personnel.

"The purpose of this technology is to assist with legitimate law enforcement functions, including locating stolen vehicles, identifying suspect vehicles connected to criminal investigations, locating missing persons and supporting public safety efforts involving multijurisdictional criminal activity," Mack said. "In Tipp City, this technology is not used for generalized surveillance or civil immigration enforcement activities."

Kettering officials say ALPRs are a vital tool that help police identify and apprehend suspects in criminal cases that otherwise would go unsolved.

‘Other’, vague reasons

Outside agencies completed more than 120 immigration-related searches of the Miami Twp. Police Department’s ALPR database in January. There were also about 278 immigration searches in February and 135 searches in March. All of the agencies doing the searching were out of state. The Miami Twp. Police Department shares its ALPR data with more than 2,600 organizations.

Records obtained by this news outlet also show that the Miamisburg Police Department shares its ALPR data with more than 2,000 agencies from all over the country. The Springboro Police Department shares its ALPR data with more than 225 Ohio-based agencies.

Miamisburg and Springboro police denied this news outlet’s requests for their network and organizational audit log records.

Immigration represents a small share of the reasons agencies access local Flock data.

In January, more than 400 agencies accessed Kettering’s data more than 240,000 times for thousands of different listed reasons. The most common reasons by far were for auto thefts, robberies, drug investigations, wanted persons and traffic infractions.

In March, outside agencies completed more than 1 million total searches of Tipp City police’s ALPR database, while authorities with outside departments executed more than 370,000 searches of Miami Twp. police’s database.

However, audit logs show there are many searches where the reasons provided are vague.

The reason given for more than 1,300 searches of Kettering’s ALPR database between early March and early April was “other — investigation.” Additionally, during the same time frame, the Columbus Police Department searched Kettering police’s database more than 1,200 times for the stated reason of “other law enforcement purpose.”

More than 3,200 searches of Kettering’s database in January were for the stated reasons of “investigation,” “information,” “other — investigation,” “other law enforcement purpose,” “suspect” and “other suspect.”

From early March to early April, the Coweta County Sheriff's Office in Georgia searched Miami Twp. police's ALPR database roughly 2,000 times for stated reasons of "other — investigation" and "other — info." The sheriff's office has an 287(g) agreement with ICE that allows its officers to perform certain immigration enforcement functions.

A variety of agencies that have cooperation agreements with ICE have accessed Miami Twp.'s Flock ALPR network for unclear reasons such as "other investigation," "other — resource investigation," "other — ongoing criminal investigation."

The Coweta County Sheriff's Office also searched Tipp City's ALPR database more than 1,900 times from early March to early April for stated reasons including "other — info," "other — intel" and "other — investigation."

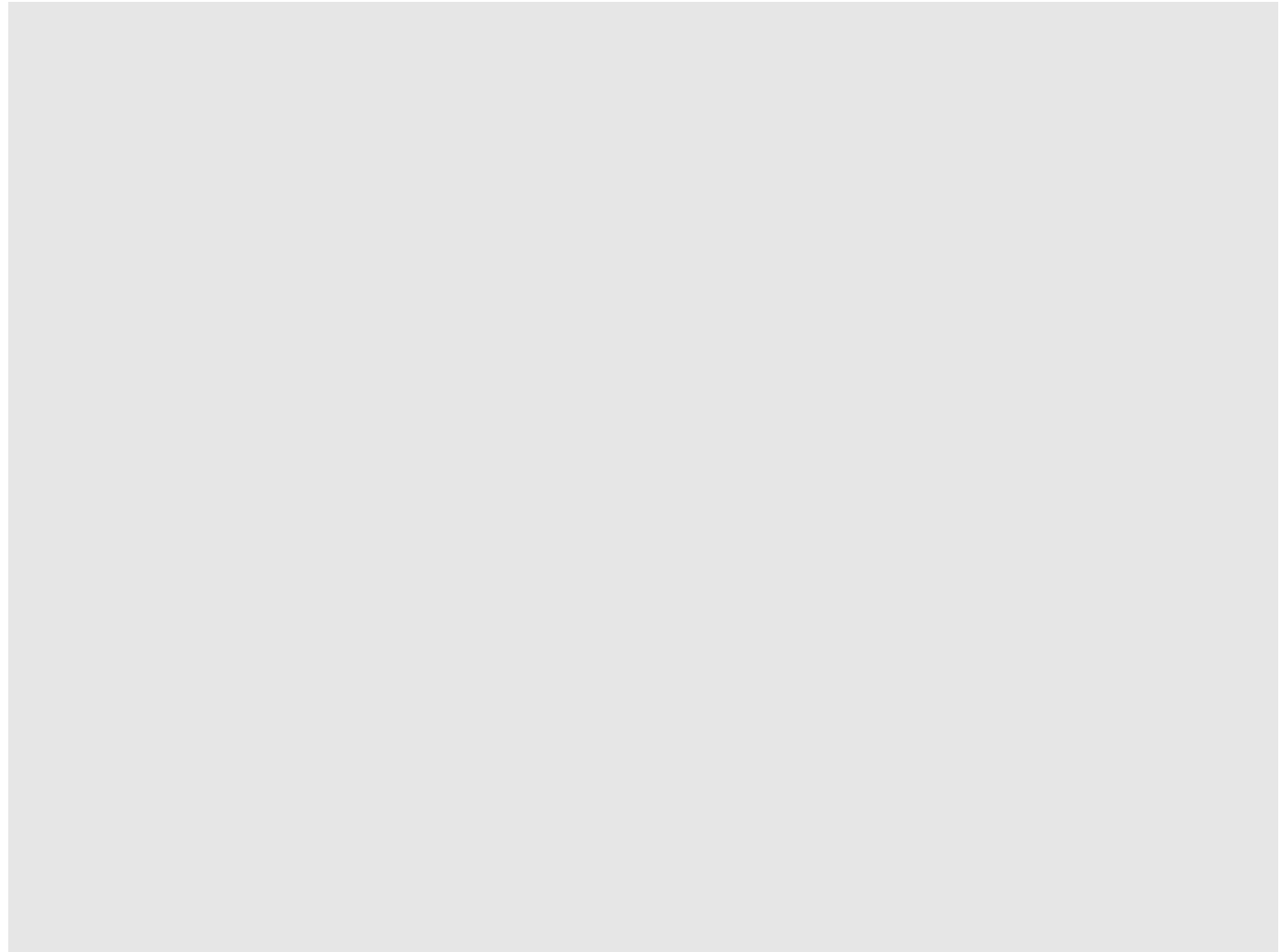
'It's far from clear'

Miamisburg police shares its Flock network data with police departments that have cooperation agreements with ICE, including the Coweta County Sheriff's Office. Springboro provides network access to a couple of Ohio police agencies that have ICE agreements.

Miamisburg police Chief Brem said technology used by law enforcement should include accountability, policy guidance, auditing capability and supervisory oversight.

"We are confident the system is being used by the Miamisburg Police Department appropriately and for legitimate law enforcement purposes," Brem said. "Access to the system is controlled, user activity is logged within the platform and officers are expected to comply with department procedures and applicable laws."

Jay Stanley, senior policy analyst and privacy expert with the national ACLU, said audit logs from police departments across the country reveal that the Flock customers share data with scores of outside groups without real transparency and accountability.



A fixed-site automatic license plate reader in East Dayton. ALPRs are used by law enforcement agencies across southwest Ohio, including Springfield, Clark County, Hamilton, Middletown, West Chester Twp. and Butler County. The Dayton Daily News is seeking audit data from these agencies. Cornelius Frolik / STAFF

Cornelius Frolik

“We see so many fields that say ‘investigation’ or other vague terms or sometimes things like, ‘Ha-ha-ha,’” he said. “Clearly there is no effective managerial oversight going on when you see that kind of stuff.”

Stanley said law enforcement officers who want to perform searches for immigration-related or other controversial purposes have a strong disincentive not to provide the real reasons for their searches, since those potentially could result in scrutiny, criticism and pushback.

“The audit logs have proven valuable in revealing the extent to which local data is very, very hard to contain once it’s collected on residents’ patterns of life, but its utility as a check and balance on this technology is slim to nonexistent,” Stanley said.

“It’s just too easy for officers to put in very vague terms or no terms at all or just lie. It’s far from clear that there are any mechanisms in any or most police departments to ensure that the ‘purpose’ logging is meaningful and accurate.”

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Cornelius Frolik

Staff Writer